



DEATH KNIGHT

COVENANT OF THE UNBROKEN

*“She didn’t kill them. Killing them would have wasted what they were.
She took everything they had been and pressed it into a new shape —
the shape of her need.”*



BLOOD COVENANT · FROST COVENANT · UNHOLY COVENANT

THE DEATH KNIGHT

The first Death Knights in Avara did not seek power. They were remade. Aalise Bathory pressed her mark into the framework of their bones — took what they had been, unmade it, and put it back together with something else holding it in place.

A Death Knight is a weapon with memory. They carry Aalise's covenant in their flesh: the hunger of the Blood, the cold inevitability of Frost, the spreading hunger of the Unholy. Power builds *during* a fight through Grave Seals — a single resource that grows as violence continues and resets only once the fight is truly over.

CLASS QUICK REFERENCE

HIT DIE	d12 per Death Knight level
PRIMARY	Constitution — attack, damage, and all class features
SAVES	Constitution, Charisma
ARMOR	All armor, shields
WEAPONS	Simple and martial weapons
SKILLS	Choose 2: Athletics, History, Insight, Intimidation, Medicine, Perception, Religion
RESOURCE	Grave Seals — one pool, builds during combat, resets after
PATH	Chosen at Level 1: Blood, Frost, or Unholy
DC	8 + proficiency bonus + CON modifier

Starting Equipment

- A martial melee weapon of your choice (or two, if your Covenant permits)
- A shield
- Chain mail
- An explorer's pack
- A **death token** — a physical remnant of the moment you were unmade: a tooth, a lock of hair, a finger bone. It is yours. It is also hers.

CLASS FEATURES

Lvl	PB	Base Features	Covenant	Seals Max
1	+2	Death's Mark, Unhallowed Body	Path Identity	—
2	+2	Grave Seals	Covenant Strike	CON+4
3	+2	Death Grip	Covenant Feature	CON+4
4	+2	ASI	—	CON+4
5	+3	Extra Attack	—	CON+6
6	+3	Death and Decay	Covenant Feature	CON+6
7	+3	—	Covenant Feature	CON+6
8	+3	ASI	—	CON+6
9	+4	Dark Presence	—	CON+8
10	+4	—	Covenant Feature	CON+8
11	+4	Anti-Magic Shell	—	CON+8
12	+4	ASI	—	CON+8
13	+5	—	Covenant Feature	CON+10
14	+5	Lichborne	—	CON+10
15	+5	—	Covenant Feature	CON+10
16	+5	ASI	—	CON+10
17	+6	Soul Reaper, Final Mark	—	CON+12
18	+6	—	Covenant Capstone	CON+12
19	+6	ASI	—	CON+12
20	+6	Death's Apotheosis	—	CON+12

Death's Mark

Level 1

Aalise pressed her mark into the framework of your bones. The body still works — it answers to something different now.

- Use your **Constitution modifier** in place of Strength or Dexterity for melee attack and damage rolls with weapons you are proficient with.
- At the end of a short or long rest, **attune one or two melee weapons** to the mark. Attuned weapons cannot be disarmed while you are conscious.
- **The Mark Knows Its Own.** Your attuned weapons emit a faint, cold violet light — visible only to you — when an undead or fiend is within 30 feet, even through walls or darkness. The light's intensity roughly indicates distance.
- Your **spell save DC** = 8 + proficiency bonus + CON modifier. Used by all Death Knight class features.

Unhallowed Body

Level 1

You do not need to eat, drink, or sleep. Instead you enter a **4-hour death-trance** — dimly aware of your surroundings, able to make Perception checks with advantage.

- **Resistance** to necrotic and poison damage.
- **Immunity** to disease.
- You are *death-touched*, not undead. Turn Undead does not affect you. Undead sense you as not-quite-kin and do not automatically treat you as hostile.

Covenant Path

Level 1

You commit to one of three Covenants — **Blood**, **Frost**, or **Unholy** — each connected to a different aspect of Aalise Bathory's vampiric power. Your path grants features at levels 2, 3, 6, 7, 10, 13, 15, and 18.

Grave Seals

Level 2

The mark generates power as you fight — not stored between battles, but built *during* them, pressure that grows the longer the violence continues.

Maximum Grave Seals = your CON modifier + a base value that increases by level:

Levels	Seal Max
2–4	CON modifier + 4
5–8	CON modifier + 6
9–12	CON modifier + 8
13–16	CON modifier + 10
17–20	CON modifier + 12

You start each combat with 0 Seals. Your pool fills as you fight:

Source	Seals Gained
Start of each of your turns	+1
Hit a creature with a melee weapon attack (once per turn)	+1
Any creature within 30 ft drops to 0 HP	+2
Covenant-specific sources	Varies

Seals reset to 0 one minute after combat ends — 60 seconds without dealing or taking damage. Spending Seals generates no secondary resource. They are spent and gone.

Covenant Strike

Level 2 • Cost: 3 Grave Seals • Bonus action

Each Covenant has its own version of this feature — your primary Seal-spend, the thing you do with a good round's generation. *See your Covenant's section.*

Death Grip

Level 3 • Cost: 2 Grave Seals • Bonus action

Target one creature you can see within **60 ft.**

- **Failed STR save** (DC = spell save DC): Pulled in a straight line to the nearest unoccupied space within 5 ft of you. Make **one free melee weapon attack** against them as they arrive.
- **Successful save:** Pulled **20 ft** toward you. No free attack.

Reaction use: You may also use Death Grip as a **reaction** when a creature within 60 ft willingly moves away from you — the moment they start moving.

Extra Attack

Level 5

You may attack **twice** when you take the Attack action on your turn.

Death and Decay

Level 6 • Cost: 5 Grave Seals • Action, Instantaneous

You erupt with necrotic force in a **15-ft radius centered on yourself**. Each hostile creature in range makes a **CON save**, taking **2d8 + your CON modifier necrotic damage** on a failure (half on success).

You regain HP equal to half the total damage dealt across all targets (rounded down).

Scales: 3d8 + CON modifier at level 11 • 4d8 + CON modifier at level 17.

Dark Presence

Level 9

The death seeping from you has accumulated enough to have weight. You emit a **10-ft aura** of death-touch that cannot be suppressed.

- **Pressure.** At the start of each hostile creature's turn, if they are within 10 ft of you, you gain **+1 Grave Seal** (no limit — multiple enemies in your aura each generate a Seal at the start of their own turn).
- When a creature within 10 ft of you dies, gain **+1 Grave Seal** in addition to the normal +2 from drops to 0 HP. A kill in your aura nets **3 Seals total**.

Each Covenant adds a secondary effect to Dark Presence — see your Covenant's section.

Anti-Magic Shell

Level 11 • Cost: 3 Grave Seals to activate • Bonus action or Reaction • Twice per short rest

Raise the shell. Lasts **1 round**. While active:

- **Resistance** to all damage from spells.
- **Advantage** on saves against spells and magical effects.
- **Cannot be charmed, frightened, or put to sleep** by spells.
- When you succeed on a save against a spell while active, gain **Grave Seals equal to the spell's level** (minimum 1).

Maintain. At the start of each of your turns after the first, spend **3 Grave Seals** to keep the shell active for another round. If you don't or can't, it ends.

Lichborne

Level 14 • No Seal cost • Bonus action • Once per short rest

For **1 minute**:

- Your creature type becomes **Undead**.
- Immunity to charm, fear, and unconsciousness.
- Effects targeting undead affect you; **advantage on saves** against them.
- While active, **Death and Decay** heals you for the full damage dealt instead of half.

Each Covenant adds a secondary Lichborne effect — see your Covenant's section.

Soul Reaper

Level 17

The mark has sharpened. You can feel exactly where the wound needs to go.

- Once per turn, when you hit a **bloodied creature** (at or below half its hit point maximum) with a melee weapon attack, deal an additional **2d6 necrotic damage**.
- When you reduce a bloodied creature to 0 HP this way, gain **+1 Grave Seal** beyond the normal kill bonus.

FINAL MARK — Once per Long Rest

When you would be reduced to 0 HP, the mark refuses. Instead: you **heal to your maximum HP**, your **Grave Seals refill to maximum**, and you may immediately take **one bonus action** at no Seal cost.

At Level 20, this becomes 2 uses per long rest.

Death's Apotheosis

Level 20 — Class Capstone

The mark is complete.

- **Grave Seals reset to your CON modifier** (not 0) at the start of each combat. You never start cold.
- Your **CON modifier counts as 2 higher** for all Death Knight healing calculations (class features only, not HP or saves).
- You are genuinely between life and death. Effects requiring undead work on you. Effects requiring living work on you. Both simultaneously. Neither fully.
- **Final Mark** (Level 17) gains a second use per long rest (total: 2).

COVENANT I

BLOOD COVENANT

These are Aalise's most personal instruments. She gave them her hunger — not metaphorically, but literally. They feed as she feeds. They sustain as she sustains.

The Hungering

Of the three paths, Blood Knights are the ones you could mistake for her own children. They carry the mark as she carries it — in the blood, in the hunger, in the way they heal faster the more they take.

Crimson Hunger

Level 1

The Feed. When you deal damage with a melee weapon attack on your turn, you may drain: the target takes an additional **1d6 necrotic** and you regain HP equal to that necrotic damage. Triggers once per turn automatically; you may suppress it consciously.

The Thirst. You must feed once every 24 hours — dealing at least **6 damage via Crimson Hunger drain**. If you go without:

- 24 hours unfed: **disadvantage on all Charisma checks and saves.**
- 48 hours unfed: Also disadvantage on Intelligence checks and saves.
- 72 hours unfed: DC 12 Wisdom save at the start of each turn or use your movement to approach the nearest creature and make a melee attack.

Feeding clears all Thirst penalties.

ROLEPLAY — THE FEED IS NOT ALWAYS COMBAT

Crimson Hunger doesn't require a hostile target. You may drain from a **willing creature** as a separate 1-minute action outside combat, dealing 1d4 necrotic (not dangerous to a healthy adult) and counting fully toward your daily Thirst requirement.

The mark shows. A creature fed from this way carries a faint cold mark for 24 hours — invisible to most, but visible to other Death Knights and anything with Aalise's blood in it. It reads as *this one is known to one of mine*.

Suppression as choice. Refusing to drain from a hostile creature deals no extra damage and grants no HP — but some Blood Knights hold to a code: *I won't let any part of you become part of me*.

Crimson Strike

Level 2 — Covenant Strike • Cost: 3 Grave Seals • Bonus action

Make one melee weapon attack with an attuned weapon.

- **On a hit:** Normal weapon damage + CON modifier necrotic + regain HP equal to the **full damage dealt**. The target is **marked for harvest** — the next time this turn you deal damage to them through any source, drain an additional 1d6 necrotic at no cost.
- **On a miss:** Regain HP equal to **twice your CON modifier**. The hunger doesn't let you come away empty.

Seize

Level 3 — Passive (modifies Death Grip)

The hunger has learned patience. It can wait the length of a pull.

- When you successfully **Death Grip** a creature (failed save, pulled adjacent), the free melee attack granted by Death Grip automatically triggers **Crimson Hunger's drain** — even if you've already drained this turn.
- When you **fail** a Death Grip (target succeeds their save), regain HP equal to your **CON modifier**. Even an incomplete pull tells you something about the prey — that's worth something.

Open Wound

Level 6 — Passive (modifies Death and Decay)

When you use **Death and Decay**, every creature damaged by it becomes **Wounded** until the end of your next turn (a single condition — a creature is or isn't Wounded, no stacks).

While a creature is **Wounded**, your **Crimson Hunger drain die becomes 1d10** against them (replacing 1d6, not stacking).

Bone Shield & Vampiric Embrace

Level 7

Bone Shield — Cost: 2 Grave Seals · Bonus action or Reaction. Surround yourself with fragments of harvested bone. Until the start of your next turn, reduce all incoming damage by your **CON modifier** (applied per hit). May be activated as a reaction the moment you would take damage.

Vampiric Embrace — Passive. When you regain HP through any Death Knight class feature, one creature of your choice within 30 ft also regains HP equal to **half the amount you healed**. Does not chain.

ROLEPLAY — WHAT VAMPIRIC EMBRACE MEANS TO THE COVEN

Most of Aalise's Knights were made solitary; the hunger was meant to isolate. A Blood Knight who can share the feed is doing something the coven doesn't expect — read by some as a quiet rebellion, by others as a maturation Aalise is privately proud of. Other coven members may react to a character with Vampiric Embrace differently depending on their relationship to her. Use this as a hook whenever it's useful, not a mechanical trigger.

Hunger's Wake

Level 9 — Adds to Dark Presence

When a creature **dies within your Dark Presence aura** (10 ft), you regain HP equal to your **CON modifier**, in addition to the Grave Seal gains from Dark Presence and normal kill bonuses. Every death near you feeds you a little — you don't need to have struck the blow.

Dancing Rune Weapon

Level 10 · Cost: 8 Grave Seals · Action

Conjure a spectral duplicate of your attuned weapon. Lasts **1 minute** (no concentration).

- At the start of each of your turns, it makes **one melee weapon attack** against a creature within 5 ft of it (your attack bonus, full weapon damage + CON modifier necrotic).
- Move it up to **30 ft** on your turn (no action required).
- When you use **Crimson Strike**, the Weapon also strikes the same target simultaneously — weapon damage only, but triggers Crimson Hunger drain.
- Generates **+1 Grave Seal per hit** (once per turn, separate from you).
- Vampiric Embrace applies to its damage — allies heal from what it takes.

ROLEPLAY — WHAT THE WEAPON IS

The Dancing Rune Weapon isn't a simple copy in Avara's lore — it's a second mark, a piece of Aalise's gift split off and given temporary independence. Some Blood Knights name theirs. Some refuse to, on principle — naming it would mean acknowledging it as separate. If your character has a complicated relationship with what Aalise made them into, this is a good moment to play that out: every time you use it, briefly, there are two of you.

Gorefiend's Grasp

Level 13 • Cost: 6 Grave Seals • Action • Once per short rest

Choose a point within 60 ft. Every hostile creature within 30 ft of that point makes a **Strength save** (DC = spell save DC):

- **Failed save:** Pulled to the nearest unoccupied space adjacent to the chosen point, simultaneously. **Grappled** by death-force until the end of their next turn.
- **Successful save:** Pulled 15 ft toward the chosen point. Not grappled.

Immediately after all creatures land, you may use **Death and Decay as a free action** centered on the chosen point — even if already used this turn, and even at 0 Grave Seals (this use is free).

Gorefiend was the first Blood Knight Aalise ever made. He asked for the power to hold every enemy in the room at once. She gave it to him. He did not survive the demonstration. The technique survived. They named it after him anyway.

Open Vein

Level 14 — Adds to Lichborne

While Lichborne is active, your **Crimson Hunger drain die increases to 1d10**, and the drain **triggers on every hit** (including off-hand and Dancing Rune Weapon hits), not just once per turn.

Hemostasis

Level 15 — Passive

The first time each round that you take damage **without healing on that same turn**, your **next Crimson Strike, Death and Decay, or Gorefiend's Grasp this combat heals for double** (instead of its normal amount). This benefit doesn't stack — taking damage again before you've spent it just keeps the one pending double "armed."

When **Vampiric Embrace** triggers off a doubled heal, the ally also receives the doubled amount.

Heart of Darkness

Level 18 — Capstone

- Your **hit point maximum increases by CON modifier × 5** (permanent, retroactive, scales with future CON increases).
- Whenever you **reduce a creature to 0 HP** with a Blood Knight class feature, immediately gain **Grave Seals equal to your proficiency bonus**.

BLOOD FRENZY — Once per Long Rest, Automatic

When you would be reduced to 0 HP, instead drop to **1 HP** and enter Blood Frenzy for 1 minute:

- You **cannot be reduced below 1 HP** by any means.
- Crimson Strike and Crimson Hunger deal **double their healing**.
- You generate **double Grave Seals** from all sources.
- Bone Shield activates automatically at the start of each of your turns at no cost.

When Blood Frenzy ends: regain HP equal to **CON modifier × 10**, then take **2 levels of exhaustion**.

"She did not make you unkillable. She made it so that killing you would take more than anything that walks this world. The distinction matters. She thinks about it sometimes."

COVENANT II

FROST COVENANT

A vampire's body temperature matches its environment. The oldest are coldest. Frost Knights carry this as a weapon. They don't kill from hunger. They kill from inevitability.

The Unfeeling

At sufficient cold, all resistance fails. Joints stop. Metal contracts. Bone becomes brittle. The Frost Knight doesn't fight faster — they fight with the precision of something that has already decided how this ends.

Cold Death

Level 1

- **Immunity to cold damage.**
- Your melee weapon attacks deal an additional **1d4 cold damage** on every hit (passive, seeps from your hands).
- When you **critically hit** with a melee weapon, the target is **slowed** (speed halved, no reactions, disadvantage on DEX saves) until the end of their next turn.

Dual-wield option. If you wield two light melee weapons, gain **Two-Weapon Fighting** as a permanent benefit (add CON modifier to off-hand damage) from level 1. A single heavy weapon works equally well — the cold doesn't care what shape it travels in.

ROLEPLAY — WHAT THE COLD MEANS

A Frost Knight is cold to the touch, always, and people notice. Some find it unsettling; creatures that themselves run cold — or things that have spent a long time somewhere lightless — find it familiar, even comforting. Their breath doesn't fog in warm air the way a living person's does in cold air — it's the reverse. In humid rooms, a faint mist sometimes follows them.

Glacial Strike

Level 2 — Covenant Strike • Cost: 3 Grave Seals • Bonus action

Make one melee weapon attack.

- **On a hit:** Normal weapon damage + CON modifier cold damage. Target is **slowed** until end of their next turn. If already slowed, target is **restrained** instead — the cold locks them in place.
- **On a miss:** Target has **disadvantage on their next CON save** before end of your next turn. The cold transfers anyway.

Permafrost

Level 3 — Passive (modifies Death Grip)

The cold radiates outward from where you stand and locks around whatever you pull close.

- **Death Grip costs 1 Grave Seal** instead of 2 for you.
- Creatures pulled by Death Grip — on a failed or successful save — are **restrained** until the end of their next turn upon arrival.
- The ground within **10 ft of you** is difficult terrain for hostile creatures.

Flash Freeze

Level 6 — Passive (modifies Death and Decay)

When you use **Death and Decay**, every creature damaged by it is **slowed** until the end of your next turn. If a creature was **already slowed** when Death and Decay resolves, it is **restrained** instead.

Killing Machine & Frozen Armor

Level 7

Killing Machine — Passive. Whenever you score a **critical hit** with a melee weapon, your **next** melee weapon attack before the end of your next turn **automatically critically hits**. If that auto-crit resolves, it **refreshes Killing Machine again** — the chain continues on its own. It only stops the moment an attack *isn't* a crit.

Frozen Armor — Cost: 2 Grave Seals · Bonus action or Reaction. Until the start of your next turn, whenever you take damage, reduce it by your **CON modifier** and the attacker is **slowed** until the end of their next turn. May be activated as a reaction the moment you would take damage.

Killing Frost

Level 9 — Adds to Dark Presence

Hostile creatures within your Dark Presence aura have their **speed reduced by 10 ft** at the start of their turn (recalculated each turn — “are they in the aura right now?”).

Pillar of Frost

Level 10 · Cost: 8 Grave Seals · Action

Enter a state of absolute zero. Lasts **1 minute** (no concentration).

- All your weapon attacks deal an additional **+2d6 cold damage**.
- You are **immune to forced movement, being knocked prone, or being grappled**.
- At the **end of each of your turns**, frost erupts in a **10-ft radius**: creatures of your choice make a CON save or take **2d8 cold** and are **slowed** until the end of their next turn.
- Generate **+1 Grave Seal at the start of each of your turns** while active.

ROLEPLAY — BECOMING THE COLDEST THING IN THE ROOM

When Pillar of Frost activates, ambient sound changes. Frost spreads visibly across the floor, walls, anything nearby. Other creatures' breath becomes visible even if it wasn't before. In Aalise's coven, a Frost Knight in this state is sometimes called *gone under* — not entirely affectionate. Other Death Knights give them a wide berth, not from fear exactly, but because being near it feels like standing too close to a held breath.

Empower Rune Weapon

Level 13 · Cost: 5 Grave Seals · Bonus action · Once per short rest

For **1 minute** (no concentration):

- When you take the Attack action, make **one additional weapon attack** beyond Extra Attack (3 attacks total).
- All melee attacks deal an additional **+1d6 cold damage** (stacks with Cold Death's passive).
- **Glacial Strike** always causes **restrained** while Empower is active, regardless of the target's prior condition.

Eternal Winter

Level 14 — Adds to Lichborne

While Lichborne is active, **Cold Death's passive damage increases from 1d4 to 1d8 cold** on every melee hit.

Breath of Syndragosa

Level 15 • Cost: 5 Grave Seals to activate • Action

Exhale frost in a **30-ft cone**. Each creature in the cone makes a **CON save**, taking **3d8 cold damage** on a failure (half on success). Failed saves cause **slowed**; creatures already slowed are instead **paralyzed** until the start of your next turn.

Maintain. At the start of each of your following turns, spend **2 Grave Seals** to exhale again (same cone, can be redirected). If you don't or can't, the Breath ends.

WHEN THE BREATH ENDS — by choice or lack of Seals

Every creature currently **slowed, restrained, or paralyzed** by you within the cone takes an additional **2d8 cold damage**, no save. The last breath is always the coldest.

Syndragosa was not the first thing Aalise killed. But she was the coldest thing that survived the attempt. When she finally died — two centuries later, at the hands of Aalise's first Frost Knights — the cold she exhaled on her last breath found new mouths to speak from.

Scales: 4d8 (initial and maintained) at level 18; final burst becomes 3d8.

Absolute Zero & Snap Freeze

Level 18 — Capstone

Absolute Zero

- Cold Death's passive damage increases from **1d4 to 1d8 cold** on every melee hit (permanent — supersedes the Lichborne version).
- You are now also **immune to fire damage** — the cold is absolute enough to extinguish rather than be extinguished.
- While **Pillar of Frost** is active, your critical hit range expands to **18–20**.

SNAP FREEZE — Once per Long Rest, Action

Every creature within 30 ft makes a **CON save** (DC = spell save DC). On a failure, they are **frozen solid**: paralyzed, immune to all damage except fire, for **1 minute**. Frozen creatures repeat the save at the end of each of their turns to break free.

"There is a temperature at which all molecular motion stops. The oldest Frost Knights are approaching it. Their skin is room temperature. Their breath does not fog. Small creatures avoid them instinctively — prey does not walk toward the cold that has stopped moving."

COVENANT III

UNHOLY COVENANT

Vampirism is a disease. It spreads. Unholy Knights weaponized this truth. Of all three paths, Unholy Knights most resemble what Aalise fears becoming: something that consumes without thought, spreads without purpose.

The Undying

They don't just carry death — they distribute it. They raise what they kill, infect what they wound, command what dies near them. An Unholy Knight at their peak is not a warrior fighting one. They are a commander running a war.

Risen Servant

Level 1

Over the course of **1 hour**, raise one Medium or smaller humanoid corpse as your **Risen** — an undead servant carrying Aalise's mark secondhand, bound to your will.

The Risen uses the Ghoul stat block with modifications:

- Maximum HP = **your Death Knight level** × 5
- Uses **your proficiency bonus** for attack rolls
- Acts on **your initiative, immediately after your turn**
- **Cannot be turned** while within 30 ft of you
- Understands Common and follows complex instructions — it was a person once

You may have **one Risen at a time**. If destroyed, raise a new one after a short rest (within 1 mile of a compatible corpse) or a long rest (anywhere).

UNHOLY BOND — While Risen is active

- You sense its location at all times (same plane).
- When it drops to 0 HP, immediately gain **+2 Grave Seals** as its death-energy returns to you.

ROLEPLAY — WHO THE RISEN WAS

The Risen is built from a corpse, not summoned from nowhere — in Avara, that means it *was someone*. The Risen remembers fragments — not enough to be a person again, but enough that it sometimes does things its former self would have. Some Unholy Knights name their Risen after who it was, if known. Some deliberately don't — naming it would mean acknowledging the person is still in there, somewhere. Coven attitudes vary: some see the Risen as a mercy, others find the practice grim even by coven standards.

Plague Strike

Level 2 — Covenant Strike • Cost: 3 Grave Seals • Bonus action

Make one melee weapon attack.

- **On a hit:** Normal weapon damage + CON modifier necrotic. The target becomes **Festering** until cured or consumed (see Scourge Strike). Regain HP equal to your **CON modifier**.
- **On a miss:** The target becomes **Festering** anyway. Regain nothing.

Festering is a condition, not a stack — a creature either is or isn't Festering. Reapplying it has no additional effect.

Corpse Vector

Level 3 — Passive (modifies Death Grip)

The pull doesn't just bring them to you. It brings the infection with them.

- When you successfully **Death Grip** a creature (failed save, pulled adjacent), that creature becomes **Festering** automatically — in addition to the free melee attack Death Grip already grants.
- If your **Risen** is within 5 ft of the destination space when the pulled creature arrives, the Risen may immediately make **one melee attack** against them as a free action.

Rotting Ground

Level 6 — Passive (modifies Death and Decay)

When you use **Death and Decay**, every creature damaged by it becomes **Festering** (in addition to the burst's normal damage and your healing).

Scourge Strike & Dark Transformation

Level 7

Scourge Strike — Cost: 3 Grave Seals · Action. Make one melee weapon attack against a **Festering** creature.

- **On a hit:** Normal damage + an additional necrotic damage die that scales with your Death Knight level (see table below). The target's **Festering condition is consumed** (removed).

Death Knight Level	Scourge Strike Bonus Damage
7–10	3d8 necrotic
11–14	4d8 necrotic
15–17	5d8 necrotic
18–20	6d8 necrotic

Risen Scourge. Your Risen may use Scourge Strike once per turn at your direction. It cannot spend Grave Seals but automatically adds your **CON modifier as bonus necrotic** when directed to Strike.

Dark Transformation — Cost: 3 Grave Seals · Bonus action. Pour your covenant-mark into your Risen. For **1 minute**:

- Its melee attacks deal **+1d8 necrotic damage**.
- Gains **temporary HP equal to CON modifier × 5**.
- May use **Scourge Strike** once per turn on its own initiative (using your damage table).
- If destroyed during Dark Transformation, immediately gain **+4 Grave Seals** and raise a replacement Risen from the nearest corpse within 30 ft as a **free action**, if available.

Rise Again

Level 9 — Adds to Dark Presence

When a **Festering** creature dies within your Dark Presence aura (10 ft), it rises at the start of your next turn as a **Skeleton** (MM stat block) under your command, lasting until dawn or until destroyed. The total skeletons active from this feature cannot exceed your **proficiency bonus**.

Army of the Dead

Level 10 · Cost: 8 Grave Seals · Action

Raise up to **4 Skeletons** (MM stat block, your proficiency bonus on attacks) from the earth within 30 ft. They act on your initiative, cannot be turned within 30 ft of you, and last **1 minute** or until destroyed.

- Your existing Risen does **not** count against this limit, and neither do skeletons from **Rise Again** — Army of the Dead is always a flat +4.
- While active, whenever you use **Scourge Strike**, every active skeleton and your Risen may make **one free attack** against the same target at the end of the turn.
- When the duration ends, each surviving humanoid skeleton **collapses and leaves a usable corpse** for Risen Servant.

ROLEPLAY — COMMANDING A CROWD

At Level 10, an Unholy Knight can plausibly direct 5+ undead in a single combat. Most groups find it works best if the player describes the army's actions in broad strokes ("the skeletons converge on the wounded one, my Risen holds the door") rather than rolling for each individually beyond what's mechanically required. In Avara's lore, other covenant members may start referring to an Unholy Knight by title — *the Hand*, *the Procession* — names that describe the army rather than the person leading it.

Epidemic

Level 13 — Passive, always active

At the **start of each of your turns**, every **Festering** creature within 30 ft of you causes the **nearest non-Festering hostile creature within 10 ft of it** to become **Festering** as well. This happens once per Festering source per round.

The plague doesn't ask your permission to spread. You gave it permission when you made the first wound. Everything after is just consequence.

Vector Born

Level 14 — Adds to Lichborne

While Lichborne is active, your **Scourge Strike** against a Festering target also makes that target's **Festering spread immediately** to the nearest valid creature within 10 ft — a free Epidemic trigger, not limited to once per round while this is active.

Defile

Level 15 • Cost: 5 Grave Seals to activate • Action

Designate a **15-ft radius** area within 30 ft. Lasts **1 minute** (no concentration).

The Defile grows. At the start of each of your turns, if any creature is within the current area, the radius **increases by 5 ft** (maximum **40 ft**).

While within the Defile:

- Hostile creatures take **2d6 necrotic** at the start of their turn (CON save halves).
- Your Risen and any undead under your command deal **+1d6 necrotic** while inside.
- Any creature that **fails its save** while inside becomes **Festering** (if not already).

Maintain. At the start of each of your following turns, spend **2 Grave Seals** to keep the Defile active (and growing). If you don't or can't, it ends — the area returns to normal immediately.

Apocalypse

Level 18 — Capstone • Cost: 6 Grave Seals • Action • Once per long rest

Every **Festering** creature within **60 ft** has its infection **erupt**:

- That creature takes necrotic damage equal to your **Scourge Strike damage** (the same level-scaled dice from L7 — at L18, that's **6d8**).
- **Splash:** Each creature within 10 ft of an erupting target takes **half that amount** (CON save for no damage instead of half).
- All consumed Festering conditions end.

AFTERMATH

For each creature that drops to **0 HP** from Apocalypse, raise a **Ghoul** (MM stat block, your proficiency bonus on attacks) under your command immediately. It acts on your initiative and lasts **1 minute**, immune to Turn Undead within 30 ft of you.

“The last thing Aalise’s first Unholy Knight said before she used this ability was: ‘Stand back.’ She did not specify how far. The craters are still there. They’re considered holy ground now. The Death Knight never corrected them. It seemed rude.”

FEATS

Three general feats open to any Death Knight, plus four feats per Covenant — each tied to a distinct sub-identity within that path. Two Death Knights of the same Covenant can feel completely different depending on which feats they’ve taken. Half-feats grant a +1 ability score increase.

General Feats

Unyielding Mark

Half-feat · Prerequisite: Death Knight

The mark doesn’t wait for permission to start working.

- **+1 Constitution** (max 20)
- At the start of combat, before initiative is rolled, gain **1 Grave Seal** automatically.
- When you spend Grave Seals on **Covenant Strike** and the attack misses, you only spend **half the Seal cost** (round up).

Grim Reckoning

Prerequisite: Death Knight

You’ve learned to read the room before the room knows it’s been read.

- Once per turn, when you reduce a creature to 0 HP, **one ability you’ve used this turn that costs Grave Seals has its Seal cost refunded** (your choice, if multiple qualify).
- While any hostile creature is within 10 ft of you, your Grave Seal generation from “start of turn” increases from +1 to +2.

This works even before level 9 — it measures the same 10 ft as Dark Presence, just without the L9 features attached.

Walking Grave

Prerequisite: Death Knight, 6th level

Death and Decay isn’t just something you do. It’s something you are, a little, all the time.

- **Death and Decay’s Seal cost is reduced from 5 to 3.**
- You may use Death and Decay **even at 0 Grave Seals**, by instead taking **1d6 damage** (no save, can’t be reduced) as the cost. The grave doesn’t need fuel. It needs you.

Blood Covenant Feats

Crimson Ascendant — The Predator

Prerequisite: Death Knight, Blood Covenant

The hunger has refined itself. It knows exactly where to drink, and it doesn’t stop at one.

- Your **Crimson Hunger drain die increases from 1d6 to 1d8** (or **1d10** against a target that is currently **Wounded**, replacing 1d8 — the dice don’t stack, use the bigger one).
- When you reduce a creature to 0 HP via Crimson Hunger’s drain, you may immediately move up to half your speed toward the nearest hostile creature without provoking opportunity attacks.
- At **full HP**, Crimson Hunger’s drain still triggers — instead of healing, gain **1 Grave Seal** instead.

Kiss of the Coven — The Courtier

Prerequisite: Death Knight, Blood Covenant

You’ve learned that a bite doesn’t have to be a wound. Sometimes it’s an introduction.

- When **Crimson Hunger's drain** damages a creature, that creature has **disadvantage on its next saving throw** before the end of your next turn.
- You gain **proficiency in Persuasion** if you don't already have it. If already proficient, you gain **expertise** instead (double proficiency bonus on Persuasion checks).
- You have **advantage on Charisma checks** against any creature you've fed from (willingly) in the last 24 hours.

Covenant Tether — The Anchor

Prerequisite: Death Knight, Blood Covenant, 7th level

Your gift was never meant to be only yours. You've made that a permanent fact.

- **Vampiric Embrace's healing increases from half to two-thirds** of the amount you healed.
- Choose **one ally** at the start of each long rest as your **Bonded** (can change between rests). While your Bonded ally is within 30 ft:
- Whenever your Bonded ally drops to 0 HP, use your **reaction** to immediately use **Crimson Strike** (no Seal cost) against the nearest hostile creature — if it hits, the ally regains the damage dealt instead of you.
- Your Bonded ally has **resistance to necrotic damage** while within 30 ft of you.

Feeding Frenzy — The Glutton

Prerequisite: Death Knight, Blood Covenant, 10th level

Why drink from one when the table is set for many?

- **Crimson Hunger's drain is no longer once-per-turn** — it triggers on **every** hit that deals damage, including off-hand attacks, Dancing Rune Weapon hits, and opportunity attacks.
- When **Death and Decay** deals damage to **3 or more creatures**, you regain HP equal to the **full** damage dealt instead of half.

Frost Covenant Feats

Twin Frost — The Duelist

Prerequisite: Death Knight, Frost Covenant, dual-wielding

Two blades, one cold. It doesn't matter which one finds the opening.

- **Killing Machine can trigger from either weapon**, and its auto-crit can be spent on **either weapon**.
- When you make your off-hand attack, if your **main-hand attack this turn already hit**, the off-hand attack has **advantage**.
- **Glacial Strike** may be made with your **off-hand weapon** at no penalty.

Frozen Ground — The Warden

Prerequisite: Death Knight, Frost Covenant, 7th level

The cold doesn't just follow you. It stays where you've been.

- **Permafrost's difficult terrain** radius increases from 10 ft to **20 ft**, and persists for **1 minute** after you leave (stops expanding once you're more than 20 ft away).
- Creatures that **end their turn** in terrain you've made difficult this way take **1d6 cold damage** (no save).
- When you use **Death Grip**, you may choose **not** to pull the target — instead they are restrained (per Permafrost) without being moved, and the difficult terrain centers on *them* instead of you for its duration.

Executioner's Chill — The Executioner

Prerequisite: Death Knight, Frost Covenant, 7th level

The cold isn't trying to wound anymore. It's trying to finish.

- When you attack a creature that is **restrained** (by any source), your attack **automatically scores a critical hit**. Independent of Killing Machine.
- When **Glacial Strike** reduces a **restrained** creature to 0 HP, **Killing Machine triggers immediately** (even if not currently active), applying to your next attack against a **different** creature.
- Once per short rest, when you reduce a **slowed, restrained, or paralyzed** creature to 0 HP, regain **3 Grave Seals** immediately.

Heart of the Blizzard — The Storm

Prerequisite: Death Knight, Frost Covenant, 10th level

You stopped being cold a while ago. Now you're weather.

- **Pillar of Frost's** end-of-turn frost eruption radius increases from 10 ft to **20 ft**, and its damage die increases from 2d8 to **3d8**.
- While **Pillar of Frost** is active, **Death and Decay's Seal cost is reduced to 0** (still requires the action).
- **Breath of Syndragosa's** maintain cost is reduced from 2 to **1 Grave Seal per turn** while **Pillar of Frost** is also active.

Unholy Covenant Feats

Carrier Strain — The Carrier

Prerequisite: Death Knight, Unholy Covenant

The plague isn't waiting for you to close the distance. It reaches first.

- Your melee weapon attacks made with attuned weapons gain **15 ft of reach** — necrotic corruption extends as a tendril of rot (still melee for all other purposes).
- **Epidemic's spread** is no longer limited to one new target per source per round — each Festering creature within 30 ft spreads to **every** valid non-Festering creature within 10 ft of it at the start of your turn.
- Once per short rest, as a **bonus action** with no Seal cost, choose one creature within 30 ft — it becomes **Festering** instantly. No attack roll, no save.

Reaper's Cadence — The Duelist

Prerequisite: Death Knight, Unholy Covenant, 7th level

Scourge Strike was supposed to be the finisher. You've made it the rhythm.

- **Scourge Strike's Seal cost is reduced from 3 to 2**.
- When **Scourge Strike** consumes Festering and reduces the target to 0 HP, you may immediately make **one melee weapon attack** against a different creature within 5 ft — if it hits and that target is **also** Festering, you may **immediately use Scourge Strike again** on them (paying the reduced 2-Seal cost). This can chain as long as you have Seals and Festering targets within reach.
- **Plague Strike's** miss-effect (apply Festering even on a miss) now also applies **on a hit** to a *different* creature within 5 ft.

Legion's Call — The General

Prerequisite: Death Knight, Unholy Covenant, 10th level

One Risen was never going to be enough, and you've stopped pretending otherwise.

- You may have **two Risen active simultaneously**. Each requires its own raising ritual and compatible corpse. **Unholy Bond** applies to each separately.
- When you use **Dark Transformation**, you may target **both** Risen — but the Seal cost increases from 3 to 5 to do so.
- Your **Rise Again** cap (skeletons from Festering deaths in Dark Presence) increases by +2.

Grave Tide — The Necromancer

Prerequisite: Death Knight, Unholy Covenant, 13th level

Death and Decay was always going to attract attention. You’ve decided to let it.

- When you use **Death and Decay**, any humanoid corpse within the 15-ft radius dead for less than 1 minute immediately rises as a **Skeleton** (MM, your proficiency bonus on attacks), acting on your initiative starting next round. Doesn’t count against Rise Again’s cap, but does count against Army of the Dead’s 4-skeleton limit if both are active.
- **Defile’s growth** increases by **10 ft per turn** instead of 5 ft while you have any active skeleton or Risen standing within its radius.
- **Ghouls raised by Apocalypse** gain **temporary HP equal to your Death Knight level**, and their melee attacks apply **Festering** on a hit.

Feat	Type	Prereq	Identity
Unyielding Mark	General (half)	1st	Smooths early-combat Seal ramp
Grim Reckoning	General	1st	Kills refund Seals; melee-range generation boost
Walking Grave	General	6th	Cheap, always-available Death and Decay
Crimson Ascendant	Blood	1st	Predator — chain kills, never stop draining
Kiss of the Coven	Blood	1st	Courtier — drain debuff + social leverage
Covenant Tether	Blood	7th	Anchor — protect a Bonded ally
Feeding Frenzy	Blood	10th	Glutton — every hit drains, crowds are good
Twin Frost	Frost	1st (DW)	Duelist — both blades equally lethal
Frozen Ground	Frost	7th	Warden — battlefield-wide terrain control
Executioner’s Chill	Frost	7th	Executioner — restrain-and-crit loop
Heart of the Blizzard	Frost	10th	Storm — stack every ultimate at once
Carrier Strain	Unholy	1st	Carrier — reach + passive Festering spread
Reaper’s Cadence	Unholy	7th	Duelist — solo Scourge Strike chains
Legion’s Call	Unholy	10th	General — two Risen, bigger army
Grave Tide	Unholy	13th	Necromancer — corpses become resources

MAGIC ITEMS

Eighteen items: two universal runeblades, four per Covenant (one per feat-identity, either granting a lighter version of that feat's loop for those without it, or escalating it for those with it), two shared defensive items, and two consumables.

Universal Runeblades

Covenant's Edge

Legendary Two-Handed Sword — Attunement: Death Knight

"This is the blade Aalise uses as a standard. Not the one she carries — the one she made first. She's given it out eleven times since. It's come back every time."

+3 magical weapon.

- **Rune of the Grave Seal.** On a hit, generate +1 Grave Seal in addition to normal generation (no per-turn cap on this bonus).
- **Rune of the Unbroken.** Your Grave Seal maximum increases by 4 while attuned.
- **The Covenant's Voice.** Once per short rest, use your **Covenant Strike** as a **reaction** instead of a bonus action, triggered the moment a creature within range becomes Wounded, slowed/restrained, or Festering by any means — including an ally's effect.

Runeblade of the Unbroken

Very Rare Two-Handed Sword — Attunement: Death Knight

"Every Death Knight in Aalise's coven carries one, eventually. They're not given — they're earned, usually by surviving long enough that someone who had one didn't anymore."

+2 magical weapon.

- **Death Rune.** Once per turn on a hit, trigger a discharge: deal +1d10 necrotic and the target makes a CON save (DC = spell save DC) or has disadvantage on its next attack roll. No action or Seal cost.
- **Runic Regeneration.** When you spend Grave Seals on a class feature, regain 1 HP per Seal spent.

Blood Covenant Items

Marrow Drinker

Rare Handaxe — Attunement: Death Knight (Blood Covenant)

"The Drinker doesn't look hungry. That's the trick. The warmth at the grip is not from use. It's always been warm."

+1 magical weapon (1d6 slashing, light, thrown 20/60).

- **Crimson Harvest.** On a hit, deal +1d4 necrotic, and regain HP equal to this bonus (stacks with Crimson Hunger — you drain twice per hit).
- **Bottomless Cup.** When Crimson Hunger's drain reduces a creature to 0 HP, immediately throw Marrow Drinker at a different hostile creature within 60 ft as a free action. On a hit, this also triggers Crimson Hunger's drain. The axe returns at the start of your next turn.

The Court's Invitation

Rare Wondrous Item (folded letter) — Attunement: Death Knight (Blood Covenant)

"Aalise sends these to Knights she expects to be seen in places she cannot go herself. The letter is blank until you need it to say something."

- **Advantage on Charisma (Deception) and Charisma (Persuasion)** checks against any creature currently **Wounded** by your Open Wound (or any creature you've damaged with Crimson Hunger's drain in the last hour, if you don't have Open

Wound).

- Once per long rest, write a name in the letter (requires the creature's true name or strong description). For 24 hours, if that creature is reduced to 0 HP by your Crimson Hunger drain, regain HP equal to your **full hit point maximum** instead of normal, and gain **5 Grave Seals**. The letter then goes blank again.

The Bondseal

Very Rare Amulet — Attunement: Death Knight (Blood Covenant)

"A small dark-iron pendant, warm on a cord. It was made for two people, though only one of them wears it. Aalise insisted the other be told anyway."

- Your **Bonded ally** (from Covenant Tether — or designate one at the start of each long rest if you don't have that feat) carries a linked token. While they hold it and are within **60 ft** (extends Covenant Tether's 30 ft):
- When your Bonded ally takes damage, use your **reaction** to spend **2 Grave Seals**: they regain HP equal to your CON modifier, and you take 1d4 necrotic damage (the wound transfers, briefly, in miniature).
- Once per long rest, if your Bonded ally would drop to 0 HP, this triggers **automatically and for free** — they drop to **1 HP** instead, and you immediately gain **3 Grave Seals**.

The Unending Table

Very Rare Gauntlets — Attunement: Death Knight (Blood Covenant)

"A pair of dark leather gauntlets, stitched with small bone fragments along each knuckle. Each fragment came from a different feeding. Nobody counted how many there are."

- **Crimson Hunger's drain triggers on every hit you land on your turn** — main hand, off-hand, opportunity attacks, everything. (*Grants Feeding Frenzy's first benefit even without the feat.*)
- If you **already have Feeding Frenzy**: when Death and Decay damages 5+ creatures, you instead regain HP equal to **double** the total damage dealt.
- Once per short rest, when reduced to 0 HP, before any other effect resolves (including Final Mark), Crimson Hunger's drain triggers automatically against the creature that hit you — if this brings you above 0 HP, you remain conscious at that total instead of falling unconscious.

Frost Covenant Items

Permafrost & Deathchill

Very Rare One-Handed Swords (paired) — Attunement: Death Knight (Frost Covenant)

"Recovered from the bottom of a frozen lake. The ice had grown into the hilts. Two scholars argued about whether the ice was inside the metal or the metal was inside the ice. They eventually stopped arguing."

Both **+2 magical weapons**. While wielding both as your attuned pair:

- Both deal **+1d6 cold damage** on every hit (stacks with Cold Death's passive).
- **Immunity to the restrained condition** from any source.

Permafrost (leading blade): On a hit, if the target is not yet slowed, it becomes slowed immediately — no save, once per turn, independent of crits.

Deathchill (finishing blade): On a hit against a slowed or restrained target, deal +1d8 cold damage.

- **Resonance**. While both attuned: Killing Machine's auto-crit may apply to either weapon regardless of which scored the crit. (*Grants Twin Frost's first benefit even without the feat.*) If you **already have Twin Frost**: the auto-crit triggers Permafrost's slow and Deathchill's bonus damage simultaneously, on the same hit, regardless of prior condition.

The Last Cut

Rare Greataxe — Attunement: Death Knight (Frost Covenant)

“A single-bladed weapon, unusually light for its size. Forged to be the last thing swung in a fight — not the strongest hit, but the one that doesn’t need to be repeated.”

+1 **magical weapon** (1d12 slashing, heavy, two-handed). Deals +1d6 cold damage on every hit.

- **Finisher’s Edge.** Against a **restrained** creature, this weapon’s damage die becomes **2d12** instead of 1d12 (before crit doubling).
- Once per short rest, when an attack with this weapon against a restrained creature reduces them to 0 HP, regain **all Grave Seals spent this turn**.

The Warden’s Cairn

Very Rare Heavy Armor (plate) — Attunement: Death Knight (Frost Covenant)

“Each plate is set with a sliver of permafrost stone — the kind that doesn’t melt even in a forge. The armorer who made this set said the stones “remember being still.””

AC 17 base.

- Any difficult terrain you create (Permafrost, Frozen Ground) also **slows** hostile creatures that start their turn in it, in addition to the terrain cost.
- **Standing Ground.** While you have not moved on your turn (no movement used, including 0-ft moves), **Death Grip costs 0 Grave Seals**, and any creature pulled is **restrained** (as Permafrost) even without that feature. *If you already have Permafrost, the restrain instead lasts one full extra round.*

Heart of the Everstorm

Legendary Wondrous Item (amulet) — Attunement: Death Knight (Frost Covenant, 10th level+)

“Syndragosa’s heart didn’t stop when she died. It just stopped beating for her.”

- **Pillar of Frost** may be activated as a **bonus action** instead of an action.
- While **Pillar of Frost** is active, **Breath of Syndragosa’s** initial activation cost is reduced from 5 to **3 Grave Seals**.
- **Resonant Cascade.** Once per long rest, while both Pillar of Frost and Breath of Syndragosa are active simultaneously, as a **free action** immediately trigger Pillar’s end-of-turn frost eruption right now — in addition to its normal trigger later this turn.

Unholy Covenant Items

Plague Fang

Rare Short Sword — Attunement: Death Knight (Unholy Covenant)

“It doesn’t look dangerous. The only unusual thing is the smell. An Unholy Knight can’t smell it. Everyone else in the room can.”

+1 **magical weapon** (1d6 piercing, finesse, light).

- **Vector.** On a hit, apply **Festering** at no Seal cost (no effect if already Festering).
- **Carrier’s Edge.** This weapon’s reach is **10 ft** (stacks with Carrier Strain’s 15 ft for 25 ft total reach with the feat, or 10 ft alone).

The Long Road

Rare Boots — Attunement: Death Knight (Unholy Covenant)

“Cracked leather, the soles worn through and re-soled more than once. They were a courier’s boots, once. The courier didn’t need them anymore by the time an Unholy Knight found them.”

- When **Scourge Strike** reduces a Festering creature to 0 HP, your walking speed increases by **10 ft** until end of turn, and you may use remaining movement to move toward another Festering creature without provoking opportunity attacks.
- **Reaper’s Resupply.** If you **already have Reaper’s Cadence**, its chained Scourge Strike attacks no longer require the target within 5 ft — instead within **your weapon’s reach** (relevant with Plague Fang or Carrier Strain).

The Second Shroud

Very Rare Wondrous Item (folded grey cloth) — Attunement: Death Knight (Unholy Covenant, 10th level+)

“Every Risen needs something to wear. Most Unholy Knights don’t think about it until they have two.”

- You may have **two Risen active simultaneously**. (Grants Legion’s Call’s first benefit even without the feat.)
- If you **already have Legion’s Call**: instead, your **Rise Again cap** increases by an additional **+2**, and when either Risen is destroyed, the other immediately gains **temporary HP equal to your Death Knight level**.

The First Grave

Legendary Wondrous Item (iron box of grave-dirt) — Attunement: Death Knight (Unholy Covenant, 13th level+)

“Before there were Risen, there were graves. This is dirt from the first one Aalise ever dug herself. She doesn’t remember whose it was. She’s not sure it matters anymore.”

- If you have **Grave Tide**: its corpse-rising effect extends to corpses dead less than **10 minutes** within **30 ft** (up from 1 minute / 15 ft).
- **Without Grave Tide**: once per long rest, spend 10 minutes performing a ritual over any number of corpses within 30 ft — each becomes available to Risen Servant or Army of the Dead as if freshly dead, regardless of actual time since death (DM’s discretion on upper bounds).
- **The Oldest Dirt.** Once per long rest, when you use **Apocalypse**, designate one non-Festering creature within 60 ft — it is treated as Festering for that eruption only (takes damage, splash applies, can produce a Ghoul if dropped to 0).

Shared Items

Vanguard of the Coven

Very Rare Heavy Armor (plate) — Attunement: Death Knight

“Aalise was dissatisfied with every version for six years. On the seventh attempt, she stopped correcting the armorer and started correcting the metal itself.”

AC 18.

- **Grave Seal Reinforcement.** Whenever you generate Grave Seals from any source, gain **1 temporary HP per Seal generated** (refreshes each event, doesn’t stack).
- **Anti-Magic Fortification.** Anti-Magic Shell’s initial duration extends to **2 rounds** before requiring its first maintenance spend, and while active you have **immunity** (not advantage) on saves against spells of 3rd level or lower.

Shield of the Unbroken

Rare Shield — Attunement: Death Knight

“Not all Death Knights use shields. The ones who do swear by this one. The ones who don’t call it a crutch. The ones who do say that’s exactly what it is, and they don’t apologize for needing it.”

+2 AC (shield bonus +1). **Cannot be disarmed** while conscious.

- **Runic Absorption.** When Anti-Magic Shell is active and you succeed on a save against a spell, gain +2 **Grave Seals** in addition to the normal gain.
- **Counter-Grip.** Once per short rest, when a creature within 5 ft hits you, use your **reaction** to reduce that damage by **2d6 + CON modifier**. If reduced to 0, the attack deals no damage and the attacker becomes the target of your **Death Grip's** pull (as normal) at no Seal cost.

Consumables

Mark of Aalise

Rare Consumable — Any Death Knight

“A pressed seal in dark wax. She sends these to her Death Knights when she wants them to have more of herself than they already carry. They do not discuss what this costs her.”

As a **bonus action**, dissolve the seal on your skin. For **1 hour**:

- Your **Grave Seal maximum increases by your proficiency bonus**.
- Your **Covenant Strike costs 2 Grave Seals** instead of 3.

At the end of the hour, gain **1 level of exhaustion**.

Vessel of Preserved Mark

Uncommon Consumable — Any Death Knight

“A small clay vial sealed with death-rune wax. The residual mark of a Death Knight who didn’t make it out of their last fight.”

As a **bonus action**, break the seal and inhale. Immediately gain **Grave Seals equal to 1d4 + your CON modifier** (excess above maximum is lost).

Approximately **150 gp** in coven-adjacent markets.

Item	Rarity	Type	Loop / Build
Covenant’s Edge	Legendary	Two-handed sword	Any — react to ally-applied conditions
Runeblade of the Unbroken	Very Rare	Two-handed sword	Any — Seal-spend sustain
Marrow Drinker	Rare	Handaxe	Blood: Predator
The Court’s Invitation	Rare	Wondrous (letter)	Blood: Courtier
The Bondseal	Very Rare	Amulet	Blood: Anchor
The Unending Table	Very Rare	Gauntlets	Blood: Glutton
Permafrost & Deathchill	Very Rare	Paired swords	Frost: Duelist
The Last Cut	Rare	Greataxe	Frost: Executioner
The Warden’s Cairn	Very Rare	Plate armor	Frost: Warden
Heart of the Everstorm	Legendary	Wondrous (amulet)	Frost: Storm
Plague Fang	Rare	Short sword	Unholy: Carrier
The Long Road	Rare	Boots	Unholy: Duelist
The Second Shroud	Very Rare	Wondrous (cloth)	Unholy: General
The First Grave	Legendary	Wondrous (box)	Unholy: Necromancer
Vanguard of the Coven	Very Rare	Plate armor	Any — defensive Seal generation
Shield of the Unbroken	Rare	Shield	Any — defensive Seal generation

Item	Rarity	Type	Loop / Build
Mark of Aalise	Rare	Consumable	Any — temporary Seal economy boost
Vessel of Preserved Mark	Uncommon	Consumable	Any — Seal refill

QUICK REFERENCE

GRAVE SEALS — THE ENGINE

One resource. Start each combat at 0 (L20: CON modifier).

Generation: +1 at start of your turn · +1 on melee hit (once/turn) · +2 when any creature drops within 30 ft · +1 more if within 10 ft (Dark Presence, L9) · +1 more on bloodied kill (Soul Reaper, L17)

Maximum: CON mod +4 (L2) / +6 (L5) / +8 (L9) / +10 (L13) / +12 (L17)

Resets: 0 one minute after combat ends (L20: resets to CON mod)

Ability	Cost	Action	Frequency
Covenant Strike	3 Seals	Bonus action	Every round if generating
Death Grip	2 Seals (1 for Frost)	Bonus action / Reaction	Control, opener
Death and Decay	5 Seals	Action, instant	Burst heal + AoE + condition
Anti-Magic Shell	3 to start, 3/turn maintain	Bonus/Reaction, 2/short rest	Vs. casters
Lichborne	0 Seals	Bonus action, 1/short rest	Defensive, 1 minute
Final Mark	0 Seals	Automatic, 1/long rest (2 at L20)	Emergency

Covenant	Condition Applied	Death Grip Synergy (L3)	Death and Decay Synergy (L6)
Blood	Wounded — drain die 1d6→1d10	Seize: free attack drains, failed pull heals CON mod	Open Wound: targets become Wounded
Frost	slowed / restrained (standard)	Permafrost: 1 Seal, restrains on arrival, terrain	Flash Freeze: targets slowed, or restrained if already slowed
Unholy	Festering — binary, fuels Scourge Strike	Corpse Vector: auto-Festering + free Risen attack	Rotting Ground: targets become Festering

Feature	Blood	Frost	Unholy
L1 Identity	Crimson Hunger (feed/thirst)	Cold Death (immunity, passive cold)	Risen Servant (bound undead)
Covenant Strike (L2)	Crimson Strike — full heal on hit	Glacial Strike — slow/restrain	Plague Strike — apply Festering
L3 Synergy	Seize	Permafrost	Corpse Vector
L6 Synergy	Open Wound	Flash Freeze	Rotting Ground
L7 Feature	Bone Shield + Vampiric Embrace	Killing Machine + Frozen Armor	Scourge Strike + Dark Transformation
L9 Dark Presence	Hunger's Wake — heal on nearby death	Killing Frost — aura slows enemies	Rise Again — Festering deaths raise skeletons
L10 Feature	Dancing Rune Weapon (8 Seals)	Pillar of Frost (8 Seals)	Army of the Dead (8 Seals)
L13 Feature	Gorefiend's Grasp (6 Seals, 1/sr)	Empower Rune Weapon (5 Seals, 1/sr)	Epidemic (passive)
L14 Lichborne bonus	Open Vein — 1d10 drain, every hit	Eternal Winter — Cold Death becomes 1d8	Vector Born — Scourge spreads Festering
L15 Feature	Hemostasis	Breath of Syndragosa	Defile
L18 Capstone	Heart of Darkness + Blood Frenzy	Absolute Zero + Snap Freeze	Apocalypse

*“She made the first Death Knight because she needed a weapon.
She was not prepared for what the weapon would become.
She has not decided yet whether she is proud of it or afraid of it.
She suspects the answer is both.”*